

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF QUEENS

-----X
AREEB BUTT,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT
DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH
MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO,
POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-
Police Officers as yet unidentified,

Defendants.

-----X

Index #
Date of filing:

Plaintiff designates Queens
County as the place of trial

Basis of the venue is the Locus
of Occurrence

SUMMONS

Plaintiff resides at
1867 Coney Island Avenue, Apt# 5
Brooklyn, New York 11230

County of Kings

TO THE ABOVE NAMED DEFENDANT:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorney within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in the case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded herein.

Defendant's address:

THE CITY OF NEW YORK
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO
c/o New York City Police Department- 106th
Precinct
103-53 101st Street
Ozone Park, New York 11417

POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274
c/o New York City Police Department- 106th
Precinct
103-53 101st Street
Ozone Park, New York 11417

Plaintiff's attorneys:

RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS.
16 Court Street, Suite 1717
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718)522-1020

Defendant's address:

POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE,
c/o New York City Police Department- 106th
Precinct
103-53 101st Street
Ozone Park, New York 11417

POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO
c/o New York City Police Department- 106th
Precinct
103-53 101st Street
Ozone Park, New York 11417

POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO
c/o New York City Police Department- 106th
Precinct
103-53 101st Street
Ozone Park, New York 11417

Dated: Brooklyn, New York
February 11, 2021

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF QUEENS-----X
AREEB BUTT,

Index No.:

Plaintiff,

COMPLAINT

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT
DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH
MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO,
POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-
Police Officers as yet unidentified,Defendants.
-----X

Plaintiff, by his attorneys, RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS., complaining of the defendants herein, upon information and belief, respectfully shows to this Court, and alleges as follows:

**AS AND FOR A FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION FOR ASSAULT
AND BATTERY ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

1. That at all times hereinafter mentioned, the plaintiff was and still is a resident of the County of Kings, City and State of New York.
2. That all times hereinafter mentioned, the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, was and still is a municipal corporation, duly organized and existing pursuant to the laws of the State of New York.
3. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, maintains a police force known as the NEW YORK CITY POLICE DEPARTMENT.
4. That prior hereto on April 23, 2020, and within the time prescribed by law, a sworn Notice of Claim stating, among other things, the time when and place where the injuries and damages were sustained, together with plaintiff's demands for adjustment or payment thereof, was served and that thereafter THE CITY OF NEW YORK, refused or neglected for more than (30) days and up to the commencement of this action to make any adjustment or payment thereof,

and that thereafter, and within the time provided by law, this action was commenced.

5. Pursuant to the General Municipal Law, the Statutory 50-H Hearing of the plaintiff was held on October 27, 2020.

6. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, employed POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, as police officers, agents, servants and/or employees.

7. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, was lawfully present at the premises known as Apna Bazar Farmer's Market, located at 124-16 Liberty Avenue, in the County of Queens, City and State of New York.

8. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, while at the aforementioned location, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, was approached and was assaulted and battered by the defendants POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified. The assault and battery consisted of being beaten repeatedly and was forcefully placed in handcuffs. The plaintiff was taken to the 106th Police Precinct where he was held there for several hours until his release on the same day.

9. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, was assaulted and battered by defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who were acting

within the scope of their employment with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at the aforesaid location.

10. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the aforementioned assault and battery was performed knowingly, intentionally and willfully.

11. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who committed the aforementioned assault and battery upon the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, were acting within the scope of their employment with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK.

12. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the assault and battery on the plaintiff was without probable cause and was not the result of an appropriate arrest.

13. By reason of said assault and battery the plaintiff was caused to suffer severe and serious injuries in and about diverse parts of the person, and suffered great pain, distress, mental shock, mental anguish and psychological trauma and was otherwise injured.

14. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION FOR NEGLIGENT
HIRING AND RETENTION ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

15. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "14" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

16. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, did not exercise reasonable care and diligence in the selection, engagement, employment and training of their police officers, agents, servants, and employees and were negligent in the hiring, training and retention of the defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, who assaulted, battered and violated the civil rights of the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT.

17. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, had prior knowledge of the inappropriate, unlawful, and improper conduct of the defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, and continued to employ them and allowed them to be in contact with the public at large.

18. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION FOR FALSE
ARREST ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

19. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "18" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

20. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, were working within the scope of their employment and authority with the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, when they arrested and confined the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT.

21. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, the arrest and confinement was without probable cause nor based on reasonable grounds and not founded upon an arrest warrant.

22. That as a result of the aforesaid false arrest and confinement, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained serious permanent personal injuries along with humiliation, shame, indignity, damage to reputation and credit and suffered emotional and physical distress, emotional distress and injuries.

23. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR FALSE
IMPRISONMENT ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

24. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1 through "23" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

25. That on March 15, 2020, and at all times hereinafter mentioned and upon information and belief, defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, were acting within the scope of their employment when they, without justification and without probable cause, imprisoned the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT.

26. That the defendants, POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, while acting within the scope of their employment, intentionally confined the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, against his will and said confinement was not privileged.

27. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR INTENTIONAL
AND NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL
DISTRESS ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

28. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "27" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

29. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274 POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, acted intentionally, recklessly and with utter disregard to the consequences of their actions and caused severe emotional distress to the plaintiff through their actions.

30. Said actions exceeded all reasonable bounds of decency, were outrageous and shocking and resulted in severe emotional distress to the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT.

31. That as a result of said intentional and negligent acts, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, become sick, sore, lame and disabled, received severe and serious injuries in and about diverse parts of his person and suffered great physical pain, distress, mental shock, mental anguish and psychological trauma and was otherwise injured.

32. By reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

**AS AND FOR A SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR CIVIL
RIGHTS VIOLATION ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

33. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above numbered "1" through "32" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

34. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through policies, practices and customs, directly caused the constitutional violation suffered by plaintiff, AREEB BUTT.

35. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through its police department, has had and still has hiring practices that it knows will lead to the hiring of the police officers, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, lacking the intellectual capacity and moral fortitude to discharge their duties in accordance with the constitution and is indifferent to the consequences.

36. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, through its police department, has *de facto quota* policy that encourages unlawful stops, unlawful searches, false arrests, the fabrication of evidence and perjury.

37. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at all relevant times, was, upon information and belief, aware that these individual defendants, including but not limited to JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, routinely commit constitutional violations such as those at issue here and has failed to change its policies, practices and customs to stop this behavior.

38. The defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, at all relevant times, was aware that these individual defendants, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, are unfit officers who have previously committed the acts alleged herein and/or have a propensity for unconstitutional conduct.

39. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**AS AND FOR A SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION FOR
PUNITIVE DAMAGES ON BEHALF OF AREEB BUTT**

40. The plaintiff repeats and realleges each and every allegation set forth above

numbered "1" through "39" inclusive with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

41. The actions of the defendants herein-above alleged, were malicious, willful and grossly negligent.

42. That the defendant, THE CITY OF NEW YORK, authorized, permitted and ratified the unlawful and negligent acts of their agents, servants and/or employees, including but not limited to POLICE OFFICER NICHOLAS CUPOLO, POLICE SERGEANT DOHENY-Shield # 3274, POLICE OFFICER JOSEPH MORGANTE, POLICE OFFICER JAMES PERINO, POLICE OFFICER JOHN TOTO and JOHN DOES-Police Officers as yet unidentified, herein-above alleged.

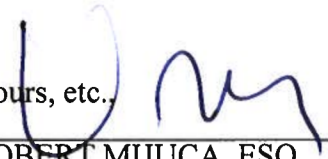
43. By the reason of the foregoing, the plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, sustained damages in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts.

WHEREFORE, plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **First** Cause of Action; plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Second** Cause of Action; plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Third** Cause of Action; plaintiff, plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Fourth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Fifth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Sixth** Cause of Action; plaintiff, AREEB BUTT, demands judgment both compensatory and exemplary in an amount exceeding the

jurisdictional limits of all lower Courts on the **Seventh** Cause of Action; together with attorneys' fees, and the costs and disbursements of this action.

DATED: Brooklyn, New York
February 11, 2021

Yours, etc.,



ROBERT MIJUCA, ESQ.
RUBENSTEIN & RYNECKI, ESQS.
Attorneys for Plaintiff
AREEB BUTT
16 Court Street Suite 1717
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 522-1020
File No.: 20AB03-15

INDIVIDUAL VERIFICATION

STATE OF NEW YORK)

) SS:

COUNTY OF KINGS)

AREEB BUTT, being duly sworn, deposes and says, that deponent is the plaintiff in the within action; that deponent has read the foregoing COMPLAINT and knows the contents hereof; that the same is true to deponent's own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and that as to those matters deponent believes them to be true.

Areeb Butt
AREEB BUTT

Sworn to before me this 15th
of February 2021

Magda Marin Colon
NOTARY PUBLIC

MAGDA MARIN-COLON
Notary Public, State of New York
No. 01MA6158891
Qualified in Richmond County
Commission Expires 1-16-2023